



by the Virgin Mary. Such relics were deemed to have miraculous powers, and there was a black market for fake relics. Some advocates of the Church condemned relic worship, while others such as Thomas Aquinas held quite the opposite view—that honoring relics was honoring God.

### Angel magic

Belief in the power of guardian angels sparked a similar debate about good and evil practices. Angel magic involved rituals such as prayer, fasting, or meditation on images, to purify the soul in order to establish a channel of communication with angels. Some theologians argued that praying to angels for help was no different from summoning pagan

spirits. Others gave angel magic the respectable title of theurgy. The popular 12th-century texts *Ars notoria* were guides to angel magic believed to be based on ancient texts written by the biblical King Solomon. The books showed readers how to seek angelic help to gain superhuman knowledge of the liberal arts, philosophy, and theology.

### ▲ Saintry lore

This painting shows the martyrdom of Cosmas and Damian, both of whom cured the sick. They also feature in some of the books about saints that began to replace pagan folk tales.

### ► Holy box of magical powers

Reliquaries were containers of relics—either actual physical remains of a saint or objects associated with a saint. This richly decorated French reliquary shows Christ at the center with Mary Magdalene on his left.

